Kunala, he had as a young man been sent to Taxila to put down a provincial revolt, this being followed at once by his father falling very ill. Court intrigue—by ministers in Bindusara's court earlier, by the chief queen at Ashoka's end—is the calculation coming into play among power-brokers of state who seek to ensure a transition favourable to themselves. The recurrence of such a pattern of departure, illness, and intrigue to indicate the conditions of regime change is essentially a literary trope for signalling the conclusion of a monarchical tenure. But Ashoka's story does not end here.

Some last episodes of his life remain to be recounted. The blood and gore of Tishyarakshita and Taxila give way to a pleasanter, gentler tapestry of the dying days, 'dana' being the peg on which the *Ashokavadana* hangs its final tale, aptly titled 'Ashoka's Last Gift'.[13] From the time he became a Buddhist, Ashoka has been shown as regularly making all kinds of donations to the Sangha. In this he was hoping to equal what a celebrated householder, Anathapindaka, had donated to the Buddha, namely one hundred 'kotis' of gold pieces. Ashoka's donations, as he neared his end, amounted to only ninety-six kotis. When he became ill he felt he had to make up the balance soon and had begun sending gold coins to the Kukkutarama monastery.

At this point Ashoka's heir apparent Sampadin (Kunala's son) and the state counsellers stepped in, issuing an order prohibiting such disbursement from the treasury. The emperor subverted them by finding other routes for donation, first giving away the gold dishes in which his food was served, then his silver plates, and finally the copper. His powers clipped, he is depicted as stating in the *Ashokavadana*: 'Who now could deny the saying of the Blessed One that "All fortune is the cause of misfortune?" Truth-speaking Gautama asserted that, and indeed he was right! Today, I am no longer obeyed; no matter how many commands I think of issuing, they are all countermanded just like a river that is turned back when it dashes against a mountain cliff.'